

SANDARU FERNANDO

SECURITY OPERATIONS & CLOUD SECURITY | SECURITY OPERATIONS ENGINEER

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

With a strong foundation in Information Security, SOC operations, and Incident Response, I bring extensive experience in technical security support and mature security frameworks. I specialize in both Blue-team and Red-team methodologies, playing a pivotal role in designing, implementing, and monitoring SOC frameworks and standards for high-profile clients across diverse industries. My hands-on experience includes leading SOC operations, conducting L2 threat and anomaly analysis, and building SOCs from the ground up. I excel at helping organizations establish and strengthen their Information Security Management practices to maintain resilience and compliance.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

SOC Monitoring & Incident Response | Firewalls | SIEM | DLP | Vulnerability Assessments and Penetration Testing | Cloud (Azure/AWS/GCP) Security Architecture & Governance | IAM / PAM / Zero Trust | Endpoint & Email Security (EDR, Mimecast, Defender) | Automation & Scripting (PowerShell, Python, Bash) | Threat Detection & Playbook Development | Red & Blue Team Operations | Malware & Forensic Analysis (Volatility, Reverse Engineering) | Dashboards, Reporting & Executive-Brief Preparation | Staff Coaching & Training | Data Recovery & Secure Deletion

WORK EXPERIENCE

Carlson Marketing Solutions (Former Kognitiv-Enterprise Loyalty acquired by CORA) Jul 2024 - Present **SecOps Analyst**

- Leverage CrowdStrike Falcon for real-time endpoint monitoring, detection, and incident response coordination.
- Automate vulnerability scanning and compliance assessment using Qualys VMDR and Rapid7, prioritizing remediation of critical risks.
- Manage application security via Imperva WAF, ensuring protection against OWASP-style and zero-day web threats.
- Implement secure access and zero-trust policies using Zscaler ZIA/ZPA, protecting corporate resources across hybrid environments.
- Oversee Mimecast email security configurations to prevent phishing, spoofing, and business-email compromise.
- Safeguard privileged credentials and secrets with Keeper Secrets Manager, enforcing least privilege and secure access.
- Utilize Qualys CAR jobs and PowerShell/Python scripting to streamline asset tagging, compliance workflows, and reporting.
- Monitor threat intelligence feeds and adjust detection strategies, write KQL queries for alert tuning, and maintain Jira-based incident documentation.
- Align SOC operations and incident response playbooks with regulatory frameworks including ISO 27001, SOC 2, and GDPR.

Dialog Axiata PLC, Colombo Nov 2023 - July 2024

Senior Executive - Penetration Testing

- Conducted in-depth web-based penetration testing using BurpSuite and Nmap, identifying high-impact vulnerabilities and delivering actionable remediation plans.
- Performed breach simulations and security posture assessments through Cymulate BAS, modeling real-world attacker scenarios.
- Executed comprehensive vulnerability scans on operating systems and network layers using Nessus, including MBSS assessments for configuration weaknesses.
- Mitigated web application risks by leveraging Acunetix to uncover and validate vulnerabilities at both automated and manual levels.
- Monitored continuous cyber risk using CTM 360 and Security Scorecard, supporting proactive risk management across client environments.
- Applied industry-standard penetration testing methodologies (including MITRE ATT&CK and PTES frameworks) to structure tests, classify risk, and prioritize remediation.
- Collaborated cross-functionally with development, operations, and security teams to strengthen defense mechanisms against evolving cyber threats.
- Kept current with emerging security threats, tools, and attack methodologies, ensuring testing practices remained cutting-edge.
- Documented testing processes, findings, and remediation recommendations meticulously, delivering clear and actionable reports to stakeholders.

WORK EXPERIENCE (CONTINUED)

N-Able (Pvt) Ltd, Colombo Apr 2023 - Nov 2023

Associate Engineer - Network & Security

- Led the SOC and L2 analysis within the 24x7 SOC, triage workflows, alert escalation, and forensic logging for N-Able.
- Conducted thorough enterprise vulnerability assessments using Nessus, and proactively engaged in cyber threat hunting to detect and neutralize emerging threats.
- Managed and monitored network security infrastructure (firewalls, IDS/IPS), and directed installation, configuration, and monitoring of SentinelOne EDR agents for advanced detection and response.
- Produced CTI-based reports, trained SOC team (including L1 analysts), and prepared regular and ad-hoc security dashboards & briefings to management to enable strategic decision-making.

CryptoGen (Pvt) Ltd, Colombo Nov 2021 - Apr 2023

Associate Engineer - Information Security

- Served as Deputy Lead in a 24x7 Security Operations Center, providing leadership, support, and guidance to SOC analysts.
- Utilized Microsoft Azure Security Solutions and Microsoft Defender for Cloud to enhance visibility, threat detection, and cloud security posture.
- Utilized DarkTrace for behavioral anomaly detection and enhanced insider threat visibility.
- Used Microsoft Cloud App Security Portal (MCAS) to monitor, assess, and protect cloud apps and data access.
- I specialize in phishing email analysis, simulation campaigns, and business-email compromise (BEC) prevention strategies.

CryptoGen (Pvt) Ltd, Colombo Mar 2021 - Nov 2021

Trainee SOC Analyst

- Operated in 24x7 Security Operations Center, conducting alert triage, monitoring, and incident documentation.
- Performed vulnerability scanning using Nessus and threat detection with McAfee ESM and FortiSIEM.
- I gained hands-on experience with CrowdStrike Falcon EDR and participated in Cyber Threat Intelligence Analysis to identify and mitigate threats.
- Analyzed phishing emails and performed malware triage; supported cloud-application security and configuration assessment.

EDUCATION

BSc (Hon's) in Information Technology - Specialized in Cyber Security 2019 - 2023

Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology (SLIIT)

GCE Advanced Level (Biology) 2015 - 2018

Dhammissara National School

GCE Ordinary Level 2004 - 2014

Dhammissara National School

LICENSES & CERTIFICATIONS

- Certified Ethical Hacker (C|EH v12)
- arcX Cyber Threat Intelligence 101
- OPSWAT: Network Security Associate & Endpoint Compliance Associate
- Qualys: Vulnerability Management Detection & Response (VMDR) - Custom Assessment & Remediation (CAR) - TotalCloud (TC)
- CyberArk: Introduction to Privileged Access Management & Level 1 Trustee Exam
- Fortinet: Network Security Expert (NSE 1) & Network Security Expert (NSE 2)
- SkillFront: ISO/IEC 27001 Information Security Associate(TM) & ISO/IEC 27000 IT Service Management Associate(TM)
- Google Data Studio A-Z for Data Visualization and Dashboards (Udemy)
- Fundamentals of Network Security - Udemy

PROJECT PORTFOLIO

Secora - AI Policy & Governance Assistant

FastAPI - Next.js 15 - Anthropic Claude - ChromaDB - AWS

Built a full-stack Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) application with a FastAPI/Python backend and Next.js 15 + TypeScript + Tailwind frontend, reverse-proxied via Apache/mod_ssl on AWS EC2. Engineered a hybrid retrieval pipeline (ChromaDB vector store, bge-small embeddings) combining semantic + keyword search with Reciprocal Rank Fusion, heading-aware chunking, and history-aware query rewriting for multi-turn follow-ups. Integrated Anthropic Claude (Opus) with streaming SSE responses, inline source citations, knowledge-gap detection, and prompt-injection/jailbreak guardrails. Implemented authentication with NextAuth (JWT) supporting email/password and Microsoft Entra ID SSO, role-based access control, and multi-tenant document isolation with fail-closed scoping. Hardened the platform through a security audit: closed cross-tenant data leaks, added authorization proxies, rate limiting, audit logging, and CSP/HSTS security headers. Delivered admin tooling for PDF/DOCX/XLSX ingestion, knowledge-base management, usage analytics, flagged-answer review, and a multi-session chat UI.

Cross-Cloud Automation for Qualys & CrowdStrike CID Validation

Carlson Marketing Solutions

Designed and implemented a multi-cloud (AWS / Azure / GCP) automation script using Qualys API + Python to validate CrowdStrike CIDs, auto-tag non-compliant assets, and improve asset hygiene.

Open-Source SIEM Build (Wazuh / Elastic / TheHive Visualisation)

N-Able (Pvt) Ltd

Architected and built a fully open-source SIEM solution using Wazuh, integrated with Elastic Stack for log storage and analytics, and TheHive for incident response visualization and case management. Automated alert pipelines, detection rules, and dashboards; deployed in production environments for real-time threat detection and SOC visibility.

Automated Forensics Application for Malware Analysis Using ML

Final year project (UG)

Developed a machine-learning based solution to classify malware families by analyzing API calls, registry keys, network connections, and DLLs using the Volatility Framework, reducing manual triage effort and improving accuracy.

Web Security Audit - Grammarly (Bug Bounty Program)

Undergraduate Project

Performed a comprehensive authorized audit on Grammarly's web application via HackerOne, using Burp Suite Pro, Netsparker, Nessus, and OSINT tools to identify XSS, CSRF, and misconfiguration vulnerabilities; delivered remediation reports to the scope owners.

Demo Exploitation - CVE-2019-6447 (ES File Explorer Android)

Undergraduate Project

Recreated Android open-port exploitation in a controlled lab environment using Kali Linux and VMware, demonstrating proof-of-concept and remediation recommendations for secure development practices.

EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

Host - Cybersecurity Awareness Podcast Series

Created and delivered regular technical episodes covering SOC best practices, phishing defense, red/blue team TTPs, and emerging threats. Built audience engagement, simplified complex topics, and strengthened community awareness.

Guest Lecturer - Undergraduate Technical Sessions

Delivered workshops and lectures at Uwa Wellassa University, KDU and other institutions on topics such as incident response, vulnerability assessments, secure cloud architecture, and threat detection. Helped budding professionals bridge theory with real-world SOC & pen-testing practices.

Member - Cyber Security Community of SLIIT

Conducted knowledge-sharing sessions, led study groups on malware analysis, red team operations, and SOC processes. Mentored junior members on skill development and career guidance.

Member - SLIIT Rotaract Club

Organized and volunteered in events, promoting youth leadership, teamwork, and community outreach.

Other Interests & Achievements

Bronze Medallist in inter-school Karate Championship.

Formal training for a Diploma in Music (Violin).

Member of school cricket team.

NON-RELATED REFEREES

Mr. Haran Mamankaran

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